

Realism and Abstraction: A Cross-Cultural Study of Michelangelo's *David* and the Yoruba's *Ere*
Ibeji

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Abstract

The purpose of this research is to compare two distinct ideals of the human form as represented in Michelangelo's *David* and the Yoruba's *Ere Ibeji*, examining how each sculpture reflects the values, beliefs, and artistic goals of its respective culture. During the Italian Renaissance, artists pursued naturalism and anatomical complexity as a reflection of humanist ideals, while in Yoruba culture, spiritual symbolism shaped artistic expression rooted in ritual and ancestral presence. A comparative visual and contextual analysis was conducted using scholarly sources, including William Wallace's studies on Michelangelo and Suzanne Blier and Monica Visona's interpretations of African art, alongside other art historical texts and journal articles. This research concludes that *David* expresses civic virtue through physical idealization, whereas *Ere Ibeji* conveys spiritual continuity through symbolic form. Future research should explore how engaging African and Western sculptural traditions in dialogue might reshape dominant narratives in art history, encouraging more inclusive frameworks for understanding beauty, spirituality, and the human experience

Introduction

Art functions as a mirror of cultural priorities, not only capturing the visual likeness of subjects, but reflecting values, beliefs, and philosophical systems. This is particularly evident in two profoundly different depictions of the human form: Michelangelo's *David* (1501–1504), a marble colossus from Renaissance Florence, and the Yoruba's *Ere Ibeji*, a small wooden figure used in West African ritual practices. Though both works present the human body, their visual strategies and cultural purposes are radically different. One embraces natural realism and idealized anatomy, while the other embraces abstraction and spiritual symbolism.

Michelangelo's *David* embodies Renaissance humanism through anatomical perfection and physical idealization, while Yoruba's *Ere Ibeji* embodies Yoruba spirituality through stylized forms and ritual function.¹ These works reflect different cultural values. One celebrates civic virtue and the empowered individual, the other mediates ancestral connections and divine presence.

While Michelangelo may not have explicitly intended *David* to represent civic virtue, the statue's eventual placement outside Florence's town hall transformed it into a political symbol.² Its confident stance, imposing scale, and calculated proportions became emblematic of the city's strength and independence. The sculpture's relaxed muscles, contrapposto pose, and intense gaze enhance this symbolism, conveying not only physical readiness but moral fortitude, representing Renaissance ideals of human potential and public virtue.

By contrast, *Ere Ibeji* figures were never meant to celebrate individual identity or ideal physical beauty. Instead, their stylized features, like their enlarged heads, scarification, and

¹ Wallace, William E. *Michelangelo: The Artist, the Man, and His Times* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), <https://research-ebsco-com.lscsproxy.lonestar.edu/linkprocessor/plink?id=eee23004-3e39-36a0-81d8-3c5ae6631667>. 48.

² Levine, Saul. "Michelangelo's 'David': The Continuing Mythology." *Source: Notes in the History of Art*, vol. 4, no. 4, 1985, JSTOR, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/23202289>, 21.

serene expressions, conveyed spiritual presence.³ These figures, created to honor deceased twins, act as vessels through which ancestral power flows. Their abstraction is intentional and sacred, embodying concepts like *àṣẹ* (divine energy), rather than the external appearance of a specific person.⁴

This comparative study will explore how *David* and *Ere Ibeji* reflect the societies that produced them, not only in form and function but in the philosophies that shaped their creation. Through examining their historical context, materials and techniques, and symbolic meanings, this paper argues that both sculptures encode cultural ideals into the body of the sculptures. With *David* through idealized physicality as a symbol of civic power, and *Ere Ibeji* through symbolic stylization as a connection for spiritual fragments. Together, they illustrate how the human figure can become a site of both political and spiritual meaning, depending on the worldview from which it emerges.

This topic is personal to me not only because of my interest in Michelangelo's art, but also because I am Nigerian. Although I've always been connected to my culture, I wasn't exposed to much Nigerian art history growing up. Originally, I considered exploring another African sculpture, but as I continued researching, I was drawn to the *Ere Ibeji* twin figures from Yoruba tradition. Their spiritual depth and the way they represent human life through stylization rather than anatomical realism stood out to me. I realized this was the perfect counterpart to Michelangelo's *David*, which is grounded in classical form and physical perfection. The contrast between the two approaches made me think more deeply about how different cultures shape their

³ Blackmun Visona, Monica; Poynor, RobIn; and Cole, Herbert M., "A History of Art in Africa" (2008). *Art and Visual Studies Textbook Gallery*. https://uknowledge.uky.edu/art_textbooks/1/. 263

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Blackmun Visona, Monica, 263

understanding of the human body, not just in how it looks, but in what it means. That curiosity led me to this cross-cultural comparison and shaped the direction of my research.

Cultural and Historical Context

David



Michelangelo, *David*. Carrara marble sculpture, 1501-1504, Accademia di Belle Arti di Firenze, Florence, Italy.

At the dawn of the sixteenth century, Florence was a city in constant change politically, intellectually, and culturally. Governed as a republic after the fall of the Medici in 1494, the city advocated for the ideals of civic virtue, liberty, and public responsibility.⁵ These values became closely intertwined with the flourishing of Renaissance humanism, which emphasized the dignity of man, the revival of classical antiquity, and the potential of the individual to act virtuously in service of the community. Humanist writers like Pico della Mirandola and civic leaders such as

⁵ Wallace, William E. *Michelangelo: The Artist, the Man, and His Times* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 48.

Savonarola left indelible marks on the intellectual atmosphere of Florence, reinforcing the idea that the city itself was a moral and political ideal, a new Rome for a new age.⁶

Art, in this context, was never neutral. Public commissions were infused with ideological meaning and were often intended to symbolize the city's values to its citizens and rivals alike.⁷ Sculptures in particular carried a strong political charge, erected in public squares and along civic buildings as visual affirmations of Florence's republican ideals. Classical form, especially the nude male body, was embraced not simply for its aesthetic appeal but as a visual language of virtue, strength, and rationality.⁸ This makes me think about how art wasn't just made to be admired, it was meant to communicate something powerful to the people who saw it every day. I imagine walking past a statue like *David* in the city center and not just seeing a hero, but feeling like that strength and virtue belonged to the city itself. The body became a kind of message, a way to remind people of what Florence stood for, especially in uncertain times.

Into this atmosphere entered Michelangelo's *David*. Although commissioned by the cathedral authorities, *David* took on political significance once installed outside the Palazzo della Signoria in 1504, effectively transforming from a biblical hero into a civic guardian. The figure of David, the young shepherd who defeats the giant Goliath with intelligence and divine favor, symbolized the idea that the small and righteous can triumph over powerful oppressors, a message that resonated with Florence's self-image as a vulnerable but virtuous republic standing against larger, threatening powers. As Levine explains, Florence identified with David not only as a righteous underdog but as a symbol of vigilance and resistance, qualities deeply needed

⁶ Wallace, William E., 52

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Wallace, William E., 52

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Wallace, William E., 52

during an era of political instability.⁹ The sculpture did not merely depict a hero; it embodied the Florentine republic's aspirations and anxieties.

Moreover, the artistic climate of Florence offered fertile ground for a work like *David*. The city was home to major artistic and architectural achievements, where the legacy of figures like Donatello and Brunelleschi had already redefined civic space.¹⁰ Michelangelo inherited and advanced this tradition, but he did so with deeper psychological force and formal ambition, aligning his art with the Renaissance ideal that the human form could express not just beauty, but philosophy and politics. *David* would become a culmination of this cultural trajectory, a statue born not only from stone, but from the ideals and tensions of a city that saw its own destiny in the figure of a vigilant youth.

Ere Ibeji



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Levine, Saul. "Michelangelo's 'David': The Continuing Mythology." *Source: Notes in the History of Art*, vol. 4, no. 4, 1985, JSTOR. 21

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Wallace, William E., 54

Unknown Yoruba (African), *Twin Figures (Ere Ibeji)*. second quarter of 20th century. Wood, and traces of indigo and tukula, 8 1/2 x 3 x 3 in. The Museum of Fine Arts, Houston

The Yoruba art of West Africa possesses one of the most spiritually evolved and developed art traditions in all of Africa as a whole. Centered in modern-day Nigeria, the Yoruba world is guided by a profound spirituality of the unseen realm and a desire and respect to honor ancestors and orisha (deities).¹¹ In this instance, art is not created for its own sake to be viewed, it is created to serve a function, a perspective that was different from the Florentines. Yoruba art objects are frequently structured for spirituality, song, touch, or offering, and instruments that mediate the human and spiritual realms. As art historian Rosalind Hackett has argued, in African cultures such as the Yoruba, art "is not merely a cognitive system, but a meaningful experience" that requires involvement on the part of both creators and viewers.¹² In Yoruba culture, the value of a piece isn't based on how closely it copies real life, but on how well it connects people to the spiritual world. That kind of relationship between object and belief makes the art feel alive.

One of the most deeply held of Yoruba cultural traditions is the spiritual power of twins. The Yoruba have one of the highest twin rates in the world and believe that twins have exceptional spiritual power. When one or both of the twins die, wooden carved figures called *Ere Ibeji* are carved to honor their lives.¹³ The figures are not just memorials but are thought to house the spirit of the deceased child. They are handled by the families as though they were still alive,

¹¹ Hackett, Rosalind. *Art and Religion in Africa*. London: Cassell, 1996.
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/1581338>, 7.

¹²
 Hackett, Rosalind. *Art and Religion in Africa*. London: *Cassell*, 1996.
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/1581338>, 7.

¹³ Bascom, William. *African Art in Cultural Perspective: An Introduction*. New York: *Waveland Press*, 1973. https://archive.org/details/africanartincult0000basc_n5x7. 82

being given food, baths, and prayers. According to William Bascom, this is due to the belief that the soul of a twin continues to exist and needs to be honored, or there could be bad misfortune.¹⁴

The cultural context that produces *Ere Ibeji* reflects a different set of values from those in Renaissance Europe. While Florence emphasized individual achievement, humanism, and classical ideals, Yoruba society focused on communal identity, continuity with ancestors, and spiritual harmony. In Yoruba thinking, individuality is not expressed through physical likeness but through spiritual presence.¹⁵ This belief shapes the visual style of *Ere Ibeji*, which is stylized and symbolic rather than realistic. The head, for example, is often oversized, not to capture proportion, but because the head (or *ori*) is believed to be the seat of personal destiny and spiritual power.

Art in Yoruba culture is often described as “speech made visible”,¹⁶ blending visual form with oral tradition and symbolic meaning. *Ere Ibeji* are not made to look like the child who passed away; instead, they are carved in the idealized image of twins as a sacred form.¹⁷ This makes Yoruba sculpture not a record of outer appearance, but a spiritual and cultural expression, a physical form carrying spiritual force, or *àṣẹ*.

Materials and Techniques

David

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Bascom, William. 82

¹⁵ Blackmun Visona, Monica; Poynor, Robin; and Cole, Herbert M., "A History of Art in Africa" (2008). *Art and Visual Studies Textbook Gallery*. 40

¹⁶ Olaniyan, Tejumola, Akinwumi Ogundiran, Grey Gundaker, Adeleke Adeeko, and Rowland Abiodun. "Yoruba Art and Language: Seeking The African in African Art." *African Studies Review* 58, no. 3 (2015). <https://muse.jhu.edu/article/603073>, 518

¹⁷ Blackmun Visona, Monica; Poynor, Robin; and Cole, Herbert M., "A History of Art in Africa" (2008). *Art and Visual Studies Textbook Gallery*. 43

Michelangelo's *David* stands as a pinnacle of Renaissance sculptural form, a towering representation of the male nude rendered with anatomical precision, contrapposto elegance, and quiet psychological intensity.¹⁸ Completed between 1501 and 1504, the 17-foot statue displays the biblical hero not in the act of battle, but in a moment of intense anticipation.¹⁹ The figure's body is a study in idealized human anatomy, from the taut tendons of the neck to the finely chiseled abdomen and relaxed limbs. Michelangelo synthesizes the lessons of classical antiquity with the Renaissance celebration of the human body.²⁰ The shift of weight onto the right leg (contrapposto) draws directly from classical statuary, particularly Polykleitos' *Doryphoros*, but Michelangelo amplifies the effect through scale, asymmetry, and dynamic tension.²¹ The slight turn of the head, the furrowed brow, and the slackened left hand all suggest thought in motion. Saul Levine suggests that this combination of physical repose and psychological intensity captures "the most serious moment of choice," a moment that transforms David from a mere biblical shepherd into a universal symbol of civic vigilance.²²

What makes the formal design even more powerful is the imbalance embedded within it. Though *David* appears balanced at first glance, close inspection reveals subtle distortions in proportion. The right hand is noticeably enlarged, with exaggerated veins and muscle definition, making it appear slightly too large for the body.²³ Similarly, the head is slightly bigger than

¹⁸ Wallace, William E. 73.

¹⁹ Levine, Saul. "Michelangelo's 'David': The Continuing Mythology." *Source: Notes in the History of Art*, vol. 4, no. 4, 1985, JSTOR 34.

²⁰ Wallace, William E, 74.

²¹ Wallace, William E., 77

²² Levine, Saul. "Michelangelo's 'David': The Continuing Mythology." *Source: Notes in the History of Art*, vol. 4, no. 4, 1985, JSTOR 34.

²³ Wallace, William E. 60

expected for a figure of this scale. These distortions were intentional because Michelangelo adjusted the proportions so that when viewed from below, the sculpture would appear more natural and powerful in its originally intended position high on the Florence Cathedral.²⁴ As William Wallace explains, Michelangelo deliberately exaggerated features for optical correction, knowing that the statue would be viewed from far below.²⁵ These formal choices link directly to David's role in public life.

Michelangelo's formal approach invites dialogue with non-Western conceptions of figural representation. While his anatomical accuracy has often been treated as a universal standard of excellence, it is, in fact, a culturally contingent choice rooted in Renaissance humanist ideals of rationality, individuality, and public heroism. As the comparison with *Ere Ibeji* will later reveal, other cultures showcase art through very different formal strategies, ones that prioritize spiritual presence over physical realism. David's formal brilliance, then, lies not only in its mastery of human anatomy but in how it binds that mastery to cultural ideas of citizenship, power, and virtue.

Ere Ibeji

Unlike the towering marble of Michelangelo's *David*, the *Ere Ibeji* figures are small, handheld sculptures carved from dense hardwood, typically iroko or sacred African walnut. These woods are chosen not only for their durability but for their ritual importance within Yoruba spiritual practice. Hardwoods allow the figure to withstand years of handling, bathing, and anointing.²⁶ They are essential acts in the figure's care that connect the family to the spirit of the deceased twin.

²⁴ Wallace, William E. 78

²⁵ Wallace, William E. 78

²⁶ Kreher, Justine L. "Ibejis: Twin Figures of the Yoruba." *African Arts* 20, no. 3 (1987) <https://doi.org/10.2307/3336483>, 82

Carving an *Ere Ibeji* is a sacred act. Families commission a sculptor who is often trained in symbolic carving traditions passed down across generations. The carver must not only be skilled but spiritually grounded, as the figure is meant to house a powerful spirit. The process begins with selecting a block of wood with spiritual purity. Using tools like adzes and knives, the carver shapes the body with simplified but intentional features: upright stance, hands on thighs, balanced proportions, and most importantly, an enlarged head that honors the *ori*, or inner spiritual identity.²⁷

Once carved, the figure is ritually prepared. It may be anointed with palm oil and camwood powder, substances that darken the wood and give it a rich, reddish patina.²⁸ Over time, this buildup creates a visual and tactile history of touch and devotion. The mother or caretaker may dress the figure in tiny garments, add bead necklaces tied to specific deities, and keep it warm under cloth or mats. These acts are not decorative; they animate the *Ere Ibeji* and maintain its sacred function as a vessel for the twins' spirit.²⁹

The formal qualities of *Ere Ibeji*, such as the enlarged head, geometric body, and minimal anatomical detailing, reflect a deliberate choice to prioritize spiritual expression over physical realism. These stylized forms are deeply rooted in Yoruba beliefs, where visual abstraction is used to convey inner essence and spiritual power rather than outward likeness. Every detail, like the scarification patterns, hairstyle, and jewelry, is coded with meaning, reflecting local aesthetic preferences and regional styles. These marks are carved deeply into the surface and serve both as identifiers and as spiritual inscriptions. Unlike Western traditions that often seek illusionistic

²⁷ Blackmun Visona, Monica; Poynor, Robin; and Cole, Herbert M., "A History of Art in Africa" (2008). *Art and Visual Studies Textbook Gallery*. 263

²⁸ Kreher, Justine L. "Ibejis: Twin Figures of the Yoruba." *African Arts* 20, no. 3 (1987). 82

²⁹ Blackmun Visona, Monica; Poynor, Robin; and Cole, Herbert M., "A History of Art in Africa" (2008). *Art and Visual Studies Textbook Gallery*. 263

form, Yoruba sculpture celebrates abstraction as a form of sacred precision, with each element aligned to communicate spiritual identity and social harmony.³⁰ Thus, while the material may seem humble compared to marble or bronze, it is perfectly suited to the cultural and spiritual needs of the *Ere Ibeji*. It makes the figure both a ritual object and a living presence in the home.

The style of *Ere Ibeji* figures reflects Yoruba values about the spirit, beauty, and cultural identity. Unlike naturalistic sculpture, Yoruba figures are highly stylized. *Ere Ibeji* are carved in a frontal, upright position, with arms resting on the thighs, symmetrical posture, and a calm facial expression. These formal features reflect balance, order, and harmony, which are central to Yoruba ideals.³¹ The head is intentionally oversized, a stylistic choice that emphasizes the *ori*, the seat of spiritual identity and destiny in Yoruba belief.³²

Scarification marks on the face or body serve as both aesthetic detail and identifiers of lineage, social status, or ethnic subgroup. Hairstyles are also carved with care, echoing real-life ceremonial styles that indicate the child's gender or community origin.³³ These elements vary by region, but all fall within a tradition of idealized form rather than personal likeness. Jewelry and adornments, such as beaded necklaces, are added by family members and reflect devotion, social ties, and even links to *orisha*.³⁴ In this way, *Ere Ibeji* figures prioritize spiritual essence over physical accuracy. They are not portraits, but visual translations of Yoruba religious belief. Their abstraction allows them to act not only as sacred twins but as symbols of spiritual continuity, unity, and community resilience.

³⁰ Klemm, Peri. "Ere Ibeji Figures (Yoruba peoples)," in *Smarthistory*, December 11, 2016, <https://smarthistory.org/ere-figures-yoruba-peoples/>.

³¹ Kreher, Justine L., 82

³² Blackmun Visona, Monica, 264

³³ Kreher, Justine L., 82

³⁴ Blackmun Visona, Monica; 264

Textual Analysis

Edward Olszewski writes that “Michelangelo’s David, in its naked splendor, offered a manikin to devout Florentine Christians for the clothing of righteousness.”³⁵ This line stuck out to me because it shows how nudity in this statue was not meant to be provocative, but spiritual and symbolic.³⁶ I hadn’t thought of nudity as something that could represent purity or divine readiness. Looking at David’s pose, relaxed yet alert. I now see how Michelangelo used the nude body not just to show off skill, but to express moral strength. His body becomes a blank canvas onto which viewers could project ideals of courage, justice, and faith.

In his article on the statue’s placement, N. Randolph Parks writes, “Michelangelo’s David was not a private commission but a work always meant to stand in public, where it would serve not just as an image of a biblical hero but as a symbol of the state itself.”³⁷ This perspective shows that the was not just an artwork, but a kind of political message carved in stone.³⁸ The fact that it was placed outside the Palazzo della Signoria, where Florence’s leaders met, means every part of the sculpture had to speak to Florentine identity and strength. Even the serious look in David’s eyes or the steady way he stands can be read as symbols of civic vigilance. I not only view the sculpture mainly in terms of anatomy and beauty, but also realize that every detail was part of a public image, one meant to reflect not Michelangelo’s genius alone, but the ideals of an entire city.

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Olszewski, Edward J. “Michelangelo’s David: Full Frontal Nudity in The Age Of Savonarola.” Source: Notes in the History of Art 35, no. 1–2 (2015). <http://www.jstor.org/stable/sournotehistart.35.1-2.118>. 123

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Olszewski, Edward J, 123.

³⁷ Parks, N. Randolph. “The Placement of Michelangelo’s David: A Review of the Documents.” *The Art Bulletin* 57, no. 4 (1975): 560–70. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3049438>. 564

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Parks, N. Randolph, 564.

While *David* speaks through public presence and idealized realism, *Ere Ibeji* communicates meaning through ritual function and abstraction, reflecting a very different approach to the human form, one rooted not in visibility but in spiritual presence. In her study of Yoruba twin traditions, Elisha Renne notes, “Anything that was done for the living twin would be done for the dead twin statue as well, in part to prevent the latter from enticing the living twin to die... sacrifices... were being made for the twins”³⁹ This quote reveals how *Ere Ibeji* are not passive objects but active participants in family and spiritual life. I found it powerful that these figures are treated as living children because they hold the spirit of the twin who passed. It made me reflect on how the value of a sculpture in Yoruba culture isn't tied to how much it resembles someone physically, but how well it fulfills a spiritual role. The figure's stylized face, rounded head, and balanced posture aren't about showing the body, they're about inviting the spirit. I view the sculpture not as lacking detail, but as intentionally crafted to maintain a sacred relationship.

According to Monica Visona et al., “The large head of the figure reflects Yoruba belief that the head houses an individual's spirit and destiny, and so it is enlarged in sculpture to express this importance.”⁴⁰ This helps explain why so many *Ere Ibeji* figures have heads that look oversized compared to their bodies. It wasn't just a stylistic habit, a deliberate way of emphasizing the spiritual power of the figure. It's not just symbolic, it's functional. The enlarged head draws attention to the *ori*, the center of inner identity in Yoruba thought.⁴¹ Looking at these carvings, I see how each proportion has meaning.

Cross-Cultural Connection

³⁹ Renne, Elisha P. “Twinship in an Ekiti Yoruba Town.” *Ethnology* 40, no. 1 (2001): 63–78. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3773889>, 66

⁴⁰ Blackmun Visona, Monica, 263

⁴¹ Blackmun Visona, Monica, 263

While Michelangelo's *David* and the Yoruba's *Ere Ibeji* come from vastly different times and cultures, they both reflect a shared desire to use the human figure as a vessel for meaning. In *David*, the idealized male nude was used to embody civic power, rationality, and physical strength, key values in Renaissance Florence.⁴² In *Ere Ibeji*, the stylized body communicates spiritual energy, ancestral presence, and the sacred identity of twins. Though one celebrates outward perfection and the other inward presence, both sculptures treat the body not as decoration, but as a statement about the values their societies most cherish. As Rosalind Hackett explains, African artists are often free from the need to imitate real-life appearances, focusing instead on evoking spiritual and social meaning through stylized forms.⁴³

Comparing these two sculptures made me realize that each tradition could offer something valuable to the other. Michelangelo, known for his almost scientific precision, focused on anatomy as a way to elevate the individual and reflect divine order. But *David*, for all its beauty, lacks the kind of direct spiritual intimacy found in *Ere Ibeji*. From the Yoruba tradition, Michelangelo might have learned that abstraction rather than clarity can also be powerful, especially when it invites a spiritual relationship between the viewer and the object. On the other hand, the Yoruba carver, while not concerned with realism, might find value in Michelangelo's attention to proportion and monumentality. These exchanges don't mean one approach is better than the other. Instead, they remind us that art is shaped by the needs of a culture, and sometimes, placing traditions side by side helps us understand both more deeply.

To conclude, this research has explored how Michelangelo's *David* and the Yoruba *Ere Ibeji* represent two radically different ideals of the human form, shaped by the cultural, spiritual, and historical contexts from which they emerged. *David* embodies Renaissance values of

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Wallace, William E., 60

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Hackett, Rosalind. 7

individualism, civic virtue, and human perfection. It is rooted in classical traditions of proportion, realism, and the belief that the human body reflects divine order. Meanwhile, *Ere Ibeji* reflects a Yoruba worldview that values spiritual presence, ancestral continuity, and the power of symbolic abstraction. Its forms may not follow anatomical accuracy, but they speak deeply to identity, community, and cosmological balance. What became clear through this comparison is that both works, in their own ways, use the human body to carry cultural meaning. The body is not neutral—it becomes a message, a container of values. Where Michelangelo aimed to show what man could become through virtue and strength, the Yoruba sculptor created a form to honor and sustain the spirit of the deceased. Both artists sculpted not only for beauty, but for belief.

This cross-cultural analysis also reshaped my understanding of art. I began the project with admiration for Michelangelo's technical mastery, but as I studied Yoruba art, I realized that abstraction, too, requires vision and intentionality. If Michelangelo had learned from Yoruba traditions, perhaps he would have seen how form can be used to connect the physical and spiritual. Likewise, a Yoruba carver might have drawn inspiration from Michelangelo's interest in ideal form and symbolic scale. Rather than placing one above the other, this comparison revealed how different artistic choices reflect different understandings of life, spirit, and society.

Finally, this research helped me confront the limits of Eurocentric standards in art history. It reminded me that what counts as “sophisticated” or “advanced” depends on whose values are being centered. If I were to continue this work, I would want to explore how African art can be used not just as a contrast to European art, but as a lens through which to reinterpret it—and how both can challenge us to think more deeply about what art is truly for.

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<https://muse.jhu.edu/book/67831>.

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<https://research-ebsco-com.lscsproxy.lonestar.edu/linkprocessor/plink?id=eee23004-3e39-36a0-81d8-3c5ae6631667>.